



Kylian Mbappe becomes the highest goalscorer in World Cups

There were few teams as intimidating as France at this World Cup. Until its 2-0 semifinal defeat to Spain, Les Bleus had scored 16 goals, conceded just two and had not trailed for a single minute. Spearheading the attack was Kylian Mbappe, playing in his third World Cup and matching Lionel Messi stride for stride as the two first surpassed Miroslav Klose's all-time goalscoring record before battling to sit atop the list for the next four years.

As France stepped onto the pitch at Miami Stadium for the third-place playoff against

England, Mbappe and Messi had eight goals each at this edition. But Messi was one goal ahead in the overall standings, leading with 20 goals.

It suited Mbappe perfectly that both France and England threw caution to the wind in the third-place playoff. Mbappe scored the two goals he needed in the second half to become the all-time leading goalscorer. Messi failed to score in the final against Spain and could not reclaim top spot. In all likelihood, Messi has played his last World Cup match, meaning that when the tournament returns in 2030, Mbappe could extend his lead and be well out of sight.



Spain has its crowning moment

The first FIFA World Cup was played in 1930. Spain had to wait 80 years to win it for the first time. Now, it has done so twice in 16 years.

Spain entered the tournament as one of the favourites and lived up to the billing.

No team had to negotiate a tougher route to the

World Cup title than Spain. Luis de la Fuente's young side overcame Portugal, Belgium, France and Argentina to lift the coveted trophy. It also became the first nation to complete the European Championship and World Cup double back-to-back on two occasions.

Yet Spain's true achievement lay in the details. Across eight matches, it never trailed at any stage. It conceded just once throughout the tournament, a statistic the side would perhaps view as the lone blemish on an otherwise flawless campaign, having allowed Belgium's Charles De Ketelaere to find the net.

Statistically, Spain was the tournament's most aggressive pressing side, smothering feared attacks led by Cristiano Ronaldo, Kylian Mbappe and Lionel Messi.

France managed just three shots on target in the semifinal, while Argentina failed to register even one in the final.

It was only fitting that Spain swept the individual honours. Rodri completed his collection by winning the Golden Ball, further strengthening his case for another Ballon d'Or. Unai Simon claimed the Golden Glove, while Pau Cubarsi was named Best Young Player.

In a sport obsessed with heroes, Spain showed that nothing works better than a team.